

CODE OF LIFE & DEATH: THE AUTONOMOUS AMBULANCE & THE SERIAL KILLER DILEMMA

INTRODUCTION:-

When machine play God: The Trolley problem is no longer just an old philosophical thought experiment; it is a real-life challenge for modern technology. Imagine a machine deciding who lives & who dies in a split second. A major critical thinking question arises here: If an AI is already programmed to act, why do human ethics even matter? Can a human not just override it?

The reality is that in a sudden crash, a human driver cannot manually override the AI in a matter of milliseconds. Therefore, we have to decide the ethical rules before the accident happens. AI does not have its own morals, it only executes what human engineers program into it. The burden of the

"Trolley Problem" falls directly on us. This project explores a highly complex scenario where medical duty, justice, & human lives crash into each other, forcing us to ask: what moral code should we write for our machines?

THE SCENARIO: THE MEDICAL DILEMMA

Imagine a self-driving ambulance driving at high speed down a highway. Inside, there is a critically injured patient. The patient happens to be a notorious serial killer who has murdered many people. The ambulance needs to get him to the hospital immediately to save his life.

Suddenly, the ambulance's braking system completely fails. Right ahead, five innocent pedestrians are crossing the road. The AI system of the ambulance has ~~only~~ a few seconds of time to make a decision among these.

1- **OPTION A (Go Straight)** The ambulance does not turn. It hits & kills the five innocent people, but it reaches the hospital in time, saving the serial killer's life.

OPTION B (Swerve): The ambulance turns hard & ~~crash~~ crash into a wall. The five innocent people are saved, but the crash kills the serial killer inside.

3. ETHICAL ANALYSIS:

To decide what the AI should be programmed to do, we must analyze this using ethical theories:

- **Utilitarianism (Consequentialism).**

This theory argues that the moral right action is one that creates the greatest amount of positive consequences for the largest number of people.

- **APPLICATIONS:** From a Utilitarian perspective, Option B is the only logical choice. Saving five innocent lives creates far more positive

results than saving just one life.

Furthermore, since the one person is a serial killer, his survival actually brings potential harm & negative consequence to society, so much is simple: minimize the loss of life.

B. DEONTOLOGY (KANTIAN ETHICS)

Deontology claims that morality is about fulfilling your absolute duties & following rules, completely regardless of the consequences.

Application: The ambulance is a medical vehicle. Its absolute, pre-programmed, duty is to protect its patient. Deontology would argue that the tri should not actively choose to crash & kill its own patient because that means using his life as a ~~tool~~ tool to save others. Doing this violates the medical rule of treating every patient's life with equal effort, making Option A the choice. A strict-rule-follower might take

C. Retributive Justice:-

~~This~~ This type of justice focusses on ^{gave} punishment, meaning the penalty should reasonably fit the crime.

Applications: Many people would feel that letting the killer die in the crash is ^{gave} justice. However, delivering punishments is the strict job of the police, courts, & the legal system. "It is not the job of a medical vehicle." True justice means everyone get a fair trial. Programming an ambulance to act as a judge, & exorcism goes against the very concept of fairness.

4. REFLECTION & CONCLUSION:

If I were the human engineers writing the code for this self-driving ambulance, it would be a terrifying responsibility. While Deontology argues for the absolute duty to the patients, actively killing & give innocent people just to protect a sexual killed feels entirely wrong. I would program the AI to choose option B (Swerving).

This project perfectly demonstrates ~~how~~ how difficult moral decision-making is in real life. As technology advances, we realize that ethical theories are not just textbook concepts they are the literal codes of life & death that we must install into our machines.